

RAJWANT RAWAT

MORTAL FEARS

On April 6, 2021, Padam Panwar, 50, a member of the managing committee of the Purana Shiv Mandir in Delhi's Shahpur Jat area, was arrested for allegedly "dislodging" a Sai Baba idol at the temple. The idol had been removed, replaced by a Ganesha on March 25. A video later surfaced purportedly showing Panwar pointing to the idol and saying: "He was no God, he died in 1918, he was a Muslim." "*Mullah hai*," says another voice in the background.

Panwar, who's out on bail, now claims the video was fake and asserts that it is a tradition in the Hindu religion to replace idols when they become old. Others are not convinced. An FIR was registered after nine Sai Baba devotees approached the police.

There is another video doing the rounds in which Panwar is seen seated next to Yati Narsinghanand Saraswati, a rabble-rousing Hindu priest from UP. Saraswati blesses him for "breaking and throwing away" the idol of the "*pakhandi* (fraudster) Sai". "If I had my way, jehadis like Sai will never be able to enter temples," he is heard saying. In January this year, Saraswati, the head of the powerful Dasna Devi temple, was arrested following his speech at a *dharam sansad* (religious congregation), in which he called for Hindus to take up arms against Muslims.

Sai Baba, a spiritual leader, was believed to have lived in Shirdi, Maharashtra in the 19th century. While not much is known about his religious origin, the Shri Sai Baba Sansthan Trust that runs the temple in Shirdi maintains he preached "the universal religion of love" uniting Hindus and Muslims. However, many Hindu spiritual leaders claim that worshipping Sai Baba "pollutes the flow of *sanatan dharma*". In August 2014, Shankaracharya Swami Swaroopanand Saraswati of Dwarka Peeth even passed a resolution to that effect.

Meanwhile, at the Shahpur Jat temple, the Sai Baba idol consecrated in 2009 is still missing. A poster of Sai Baba, however, adorns one of the walls. Panwar remains a member of the temple committee, but no one wants to talk about the incident, saying it was a needless controversy. ■

–Kaushik Deka



HYDERABAD | CHARMINAR
SASARAM | SHER SHAH SURI TOMB



JITENDRA KUMAR SINGH

Charminar is considered by the ASI as an unauthorised construction."

The Bhagyalakshmi temple, as it is now called, has evolved over decades. No disputes have been raised, though the temple is a mid-to-late 20th century development virtually clinging to a monument that has lent its name to several brands, from cigarettes to cement. Is this a result of the city's latent religious and cultural syncretism? "Perhaps," says heritage activist Mohamed Safiullah, who laments the fact that the monument has still not got a World Heritage Site tag. "What is certain is that all four faces of the Charminar are distinctly different in design but only the southern face keeps altering and changing. We do not take care of our protected monuments."

The absence of such care is conspicuous in the visible encroachments at the sprawling tomb of Sher Shah Suri at Sasaram in Bihar's Rohtas district. The octagonal mausoleum with arched gateways in the middle of a man-made lake is a breathtaking snapshot of history. Right on the shore of the lake to its east stands the Sarveshwar Mahadev Mandir.

A makeshift structure in the '70s, it is now a place of worship spread over 9,500 sq. ft. A mosque, also located on the lake's banks, towards the south of the tomb, is another encroachment. The 2017 amendment to the AMASR Act, which bans any construction in prohibited areas (within a 100m radius around a protected monument), has little resonance in Sasaram. In fact, since 1977, the ASI has reported 16 encroachments, a few of which were dismantled. But now it seems resigned to the status quo. An e-mail sent on May 28 to Dr Goutami Bhattacharya, ASI's superintending archaeologist for Patna Circle, on the status of the encroachments got no response. ■

–Amarnath K. Menon & Jitendra Kumar Singh